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AUTHORITARIAN POWER AND CONTESTATION BEYOND THE STATE

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Prefiguring politics: transregional energy infrastructures as a lens for the study of authoritarian practices

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ABSTRACT
Transregional energy infrastructure projects connect regions anew and envisage borderless energy flows. Building on prior work on technopolitics and the practice-turn in research on authoritarian power, we develop a political economy approach to the effects of transnational energy infrastructure expansion. This contribution asks what role transregional authoritarian practices in energy infrastructure expansion play for the limitation of opportunities for contestation and how they prefigure politics. We argue that contemporary energy infrastructure projects remove opportunities for democratic contestation, and fix specific energy futures in place, while preventing others. As material expressions of specific visions of the future, large-scale transnational energy infrastructures alter and hinder democratic decision-making. They shape the context within which infrastructural politics are imagined and realized, thereby enabling, blocking, or containing attempts at transitioning towards sustainable futures. Finally, we briefly zoom in on select project sites and actors in two transregional electricity infrastructure projects, SIEPAC and MedRing.

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Introduction

Efforts at integrating Latin American electricity grids and at connecting European and North African grids via submarine cables not only quite literally connect regions anew, but aspire to imaginaries of infrastructures as instruments of modernity, fulfilling aspirations of 'progress'. This contribution asks what role transregional authoritarian practices in energy infrastructure expansion play for the limitation of opportunities for contestation and how they prefigure politics. We argue that contemporary energy infrastructure projects prefigure politics, remove opportunities for democratic contestation, and fix specific energy futures in place, while preventing others. As material expressions of specific visions of the future, infrastructures alter and may even hinder democratic decision-making. They shape the context within which infrastructure politics are imagined and realized, thereby enabling, blocking, or containing contemporary attempts at transitioning towards sustainable futures.

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The global privatization of essential infrastructures (such as electricity grids) boosted the role of transnational corporations in managing and preventing public discontent. Local contestation is made impossible or at least severely complicated. There is no common public – in the sense that local actors could meaningfully influence decision-making processes – that corresponds to the transregional spatial imaginaries ('Mediterranean' and 'North and Central America') within which the projects unfold. Authoritarian practices in energy infrastructure expansion prevent, limit, and repress demands for energy democracy, and by doing so, facilitate capital accumulation, particularly in conflictive contexts.

This article contributes a conceptualization of the political effects of transnational electricity infrastructure expansion. It builds on and connects prior work on technopolitics (Hecht, 2011; Li, 2018; Mitchell, 2011) with the recent practice-turn in research on authoritarian power (Bruff & Tansel, 2019; Glasius, 2018; IRGAC, 2022; Jenss & Schuetze, 2021). From a critical political economy perspective, we question whether the claim that infrastructure's immediacy and intimacy 'does not allow state power to disavow itself' (Anand et al., 2018, p. 21) holds true for energy infrastructure projects that stretch beyond state boundaries. While existing literature on prefiguring politics (Yates, 2015) focuses strongly on consolidating experimental social arrangements in participatory political arenas, we explore how transregional energy infrastructures prefigure political outcomes. We contend that such infrastructures set the pathways for authoritarian politics, by locking planning processes into technocratic practices that preempt contestation, by facilitating coercion in specific conjunctures (of contestation), and by partly shifting the potential for contestation into a transnational, seemingly actor-less realm without corresponding powerful publics. Drawing on Mezzadra and Neilson (2019), Arboleda (2020), and Bieler and Morton (2018), we situate social struggles around the politics of infrastructure within the dynamic, transnational field of tensions that the very materiality of these (envisaged) electricity grids implies.

Literature on the technopolitics of infrastructure focuses on the tension between an imagined promise of connection, and the actual asymmetrical power relations underlying infrastructure expansion, based on class and racialization (Lesutis, 2022; Plonski, 2022). The result is the production of connection for some, and the containment of those thought of as unworthy of the infrastructural promise (Appel, 2019; Lesutis, 2022). Work on infrastructural harm (Dunlap, 2021) and conflicts around large-scale infrastructure expansion (Van Veelen et al., 2021) tell us that the latter involves processes of dispossession (Baka, 2017, p. 978), risks conflict, and the biased projection of costs (Sovacool & Cooper, 2013), or outright violence (Appel, 2019; Li, 2018). We expand this work by linking it to the practices approach in research on authoritarian power.

What is new about transregional electricity grids as a lens for the study of authoritarian practices? First, the specific social relation with electricity is often buried under grand visions of connectivity and modern nations. Electricity infrastructures invoke modernity in a particular way, enabling lighting, movement, and communication, but the politics of electricity is even less visible than that of other infrastructures (Bakke, 2016). For instance, roads draw more contestation (Montaño, 2021, pp. 5–6). However, electrification projects have constituted sites at which settler colonialism and capitalism materialize, for instance in Palestine (Jabary Salamanca, 2014, p. 19), deepening existing inequalities, and helping produce and perform ethno-national differences (Shamir, 2013). Second, while electricity grids enable the bidirectional flow of electrons, producing an image of mutually beneficial interconnectivity, the energy platforms feeding into emerging super grids have (re-)produced forms of containment and exclusion. The materiality of oil and gas as fossil energy sources found only in highly concentrated form underground facilitated the increasing containment of democratic demands (Mitchell, 2011). The growing addition of dispersed,

distributed above-ground renewable energy platforms (PV, wind parks), by contrast, holds a potential for 'community energy' (Becker & Kunze, 2014). The decentralized nature of renewables actually complicates isolating decision practices from contestation. Third, electricity grids carry shared perceptions of possible (technological) futures (Bakke, 2016; Montaño, 2021). However, fewer and fewer social groups will share these if grids are expanded through authoritarian or coercive practices. Fourth, electricity grids embody the continuity between fossil fuels and renewables, and simultaneously illustrate conceptual and material shifts in global capitalism, as investments increasingly flow into renewables, a growing source of profit. Fifth, transregional electricity grids clash with the common imagination of politics as a realm of the state (Hanieh, 2018, p. 6). States are not rendered obsolete, but no longer project direct property over infrastructures to exert infrastructural power (see Mann, 2008). They partially grant that power to global, private players. Transregional electricity grids illustrate how authoritarian power is transformed into global configurations (Bogaert, 2018), as infrastructure planners, investors, *and* state institutions employ authoritarian practices, or facilitate them. Finally, the sustainability claims that accompany many transregional electricity grid interconnection projects – which frequently do enable RE integration – add a qualitative dimension to contemporary infrastructure megaprojects that classical highway or canal projects do not have. Such sustainability claims not only regularly prove to be unfounded (Kramarz et al., 2021), but open up a new means to push through highly contested projects.

In the following main section, we develop a conceptual approach to how energy infrastructure projects prefigure politics. In a short empirical section, we then discuss key characteristics of said prefiguration, zooming in on select project sites and actors in two transregional electricity infrastructure projects, SIEPAC and MedRing. SIEPAC was built in the 2010s to connect the North and Central American grids; MedRing is envisaged to link North African energy production to the European Union. We base our arguments on the analysis of qualitative data, collected between 2019 and 2022, i.e. analysis of NGO or consultancy reports, and on exploratory research trips to Costa Rica and Morocco in 2022. We accessed the digital archives of large-scale planning agents such as development banks involved in the grids' financing and planning. To grasp the political dynamics of SIEPAC and the MedRing project, we understand the two projects as part of globalized spaces of relational logistics. The global economy's requirements for acceleration and trade intensity put far-away regions in competition with each other to deepen the infrastructure network and become 'more connected'.

Infrastructures prefigure politics

How do electricity grids prefigure politics, and who drives prefiguration? We argue that the inability of the publics to influence the course of their design and implementation affects future (energy) politics. Prefiguration is a core infrastructural process. It is the anti-democratic nature of the infrastructure planning process itself that prefigures an exclusive and extractive logic for planetary energy futures. In this section, we build on and speak to global political economy and technopolitics literatures to build a theoretical lens to study how (transnational electricity) infrastructures prefigure politics. We advocate for a critical political economy framework, centring the question of who decides and holds agency. We draw on the recent practice-turn in research on authoritarian power, including authoritarian neoliberalism literature (Bruff & Tansel, 2019).

Our understanding of the state starts from the unequal power relations that make up the latter and which are never separate from contradictory social relations. Neither can capital interests and the state be conflated. Policies including coercion, or negotiation, cooptation and the seeking of consent are effects of such disputes. The ways national and regional administrations, planning

agencies, or civil society organizations are able to intervene in infrastructure governance depend on multiple, past and present struggles within and beyond states. Infrastructures prefigure politics, as they are material representations of this statecraft. They are long-lasting material expressions of unequal power relations and political will at specific moments in time (even if not always realized). Yet, material infrastructures also play a role in prefiguring what can be done; they establish conditions for future politics. The materiality of infrastructures depends on and shapes (re)configurations of power relations (Hecht, 2011, p. 3), in this case within and across borders.

Statecraft may become coercive when capital accumulation and political demands cannot be reconciled, for instance, when the infrastructures built do not appear as universally beneficial anymore. Bringing the neo-marxist authoritarian practices approach to bear on infrastructure means studying the transformation of key societal sites in capitalism through sets of practices in political constituencies, be they perceived as 'authoritarian' or 'democratic' – practices which 'further protect spaces and circuits of capitalist accumulation' (Bruff & Tansel, 2019, p. 8). Electricity grids are key sites where such practices have proven to be effective. The dynamism of transnational electricity infrastructures as such key sites makes each node of the system a niche for accumulation; it is lucrative for capital to design, promote, finance, build and operate stretches of infrastructure, but not necessarily beneficial to local populations.

In consequence, analyses of transnational infrastructure expansion need to recognize that the quest for new spaces of capital accumulation enabled by infrastructure expansion across borders has driven the employment of a spectrum of antidemocratic practices, as energy projects feeding into electricity grids have been highly contested. Such a reading highlights how such projects have increasingly relied on practices that mobilize administrative and coercive institutions both at the state scale, and beyond, to legitimize and shield them from socio-political contestation in the context of perpetuated crises (see Bruff & Tansel, 2019; Brown, 2019, p. 7). As grids are presented as essential for 'the reliability of capital and labour flows' (Anand et al., 2018, p. 5), governments see their expansion as necessary despite potential conflict.

In our conceptualization of authoritarian practices, the question of agency is core. We should not reduce authoritarian practices to some agent-less capitalist logic alone. This would obscure 'a vast spectrum of governance techniques' (Bruff & Tansel, 2019, p. 7) available in capitalist social relations. While contemporary global capitalism may at first sight seem actor – and object-less, specific actors drive the infrastructure expansions we study. It is the social relations around their contemporary planning processes, defined by unequal power relations, that prefigure the realm of the possible for future politics. Agency is not ahistorical; political practices shift at specific moments and sites. Less reliable infrastructure, fraught interconnection, or conflicts in the planning process may slow down the process of infrastructure expansion, influencing who holds agency and power over the process.

We introduce two dimensions of differentiating agency. First, technopolitics approaches benefit from tying in at a more basic conceptual level class and race, and social struggles affected by infrastructure construction. Practices predicated on or promoting the transregional flow of energy may differ only marginally at different sites of globalized infrastructure spaces, but have different impacts on different members of emerging transregional publics. Infrastructure studies benefit from focusing on the 'particular, gendered, racialized and localized effects' (Bruff & Tansel, 2019, p. 4), and from new technopolitical work (i.e. Lesutis, 2022) on the selectivity of the publics that projects speak to. For instance, authoritarian practices in transregional electricity grids allow for imaginaries of unrestricted opportunities for capital accumulation, formally freed from possible demands of local populations, which project plans frequently construct as passive and 'stuck in the past'. Second, a relational approach foregrounds the agency of those affected; they are not external

to capitalist processes. The 'excluded social forces, whose consent has not been won, whose interests have not been taken into account, form the basis of counter-movements, resistance, alternative strategies and visions' (Hall, cited in Bruff & Tansel, 2019, p. 6). And yet, while infrastructures bypass some actors, others may find their infrastructural promise in being newly connected to the infrastructural network (Anand et al., 2018).

Once built, infrastructure contains political possibilities. In effect, large-scale transregional infrastructure projects can preclude democratic energy futures. Transnational electricity grids are both effects of spatial rearticulations and produce them, altering social relations in the spaces affected by large-scale infrastructures, sometimes inhibiting human mobility, and rearranging local power relations through transnational planning. Participation in their planning, and thus in shaping future politics of energy, is severely limited. In consequence, only partial and particular images of a desirable future and infrastructure materiality make up the dominant imaginaries, and precisely these shape context-specific governance practices and ideas of what is desirable and 'modern' (Lesutis, 2022; Montaño, 2021). The large-scale set-up prefigures possible alternatives of energy, property relations, and negotiation of basic services, as is electricity. Such political effects are potentially territorially unbounded and not neatly delimited by administrative boundaries. Indeed, different sites of infrastructure expansion are relational spaces that (re-)produce one another, where social relations are re-linked and reconfigured through infrastructure construction.

How exactly do global infrastructure players (attempt to) remove decision-making processes from (opportunities for) democratic contestation? We suggest the following three sets of practices through which this prefiguration takes place during the process of infrastructure planning. Through preemptive and technocratic practices, dominant stakeholders render infrastructure projects seemingly apolitical and shape processes according to their own risk calculations (see Jenss & Schuetze, 2021). State coercion and privatized violence are obvious elements of curtailing contestation. Finally, the prefiguration of politics takes place by shifting the field of (political) tensions into a transregional realm, where it is harder to organize effective contestation, as part of the spatial fix of political economy that transcends the state. An essential, if overlooked element of this is the link between energy infrastructures and migration containment infrastructures, rendering the former an integral part of coercive, militarized landscapes of migration deterrence. This goes beyond limiting the access to decision-making over the infrastructural governance process or marginalizing particular stakeholders in the process.

Antidemocratic practices: technocratic practices prevent, coercive practices curtail contestation

The prefiguration of politics takes place through technocratic practices, as a vast body of literature has shown. Seemingly apolitical practices of 'development' and 'improvement' have had deeply antidemocratic effects (Mitchell, 2002). Energy infrastructures fix in place more or less democratic (energy) politics through distributed or concentrated governance set-ups (Burke & Stephens, 2018, p. 82; Folkers, 2016). The materiality of different energy sources and associated infrastructures entails different disruptive potentials (Mitchell, 2011, p. 236).

In analysing electricity grids' political effects, we suggest to unpack the technocratic practices involved in their planning. The primacy of globalized networks and cost calculations in energy expansion can – depending on context – be achieved via either eliminating existing democratic practices, or their radical depletion via a narrow procedural understanding of democracy. Following Brown's (2019, p. 7) argument about rising antidemocratic politics, neoliberal rationality and

privatization 'prepared the ground for the mobilization and legitimacy of ferocious antidemocratic forces'. This prefigures authoritarian futures and marginalizes and bypasses other territories and people.

Practices that prevent dissent are frequent in infrastructure expansion. What is authoritarian about these? First, proponents of expansion frequently detach decision-making arenas – and transnational grids' large-scale administrative set-ups – from parliaments and local structures of decision-making. Instead, they relegate them to expert rounds and private operators, that is to a transnational realm that local actors struggle much more to influence, given its opaqueness and seeming spatial detachment (Van Veelen et al., 2021). Both the formal transfer of local decision-making processes into private hands, and formally maintaining or promoting procedural democracy, which lacks emancipatory potential, constitute, in essence, deeply antidemocratic practices (Schuetze, 2019). In consequence, transnational electricity grids are hardly discussed with the populations on-site and affected by, for instance, land titling disputes and other localized effects of infrastructure construction. Their decision-making, planning and execution are highly asymmetrical, the rerouting of infrastructures via negotiation an exception. This lack of participatory processes and the existence of interest groups affected by, but uninvolved in, decision-making on infrastructures has led to critiques of energy colonialism (Allan et al., 2021; Batel & Devine-Wright, 2017). This impeded democratic decision-making processes, and distanced any protest 'on the ground' from the actual arenas of the politics of infrastructure.

Second, technocratizing practices, in our rethinking of authoritarian power, hold connotations of 'improvement'. Such practices introduce 'improved' management processes and make local populations appear as 'others' to be developed. They give authoritarian practices a purpose ('development') and freeze or deepen inequalities by depoliticizing them and obstructing contestation. Technocratizing practices, such as universal measures and quality controls (Easterling, 2014), bring different sites into the same entangled context, may homogenize the built environment itself, and turn political questions into technical matters. However, technical standards in emerging transregional energy infrastructures are anything but apolitical, and instead the topic of increasing geo-economic competition (Westphal et al., 2021, pp. 27–28). It is hardly new that bilateral Investment Treaties (between countries of origin of infrastructure investors) with investment guarantees function as preemptive practices. If states change regulations in reaction to protests, they may get sued. Currently, the World Bank International Centre for the Settlement of Investment Disputes (ICSID, 2022) has 283 cases pending, 6 of which revolve precisely around electricity distribution rights. In the face of the state's legal obligations, protest may become futile.

Third, by including contestation into complex risk calculations – risk always understood as potential impediments to the projects of concern, not their own risky *effects* – global infrastructure players ensure that their projects succeed even in the face of contestation. Pre-emptive measures avoid disruptions that could impair investment guarantees. For instance, the 2016 KPMG report argues that due to 'geopolitical and social upheaval […] investors will need to get comfortable with uncertainty' (KPMG, 2016). Global infrastructure planning advisors argue that such plans need to be 'future-proof' (KPMG, 2018, p. 6) and must include socio-political conflict into their risk calculations. Labour action in one location may disrupt a supply chain at a particular site, and affect far-distant places. Securing transregional infrastructures, then, means insuring against additional costs, and preventing 'major events' of protest, urban upheaval, and infrastructure disruption through strikes. An analysis of infrastructures' political effects should explore how insurance companies, investment agreements that disable states from withdrawing large-scale projects, and direct lobbying, protect investments.

Fourth, infrastructure vulnerability discourses themselves need to be scrutinized, as their technocratization disables future contestation. The relatively open contempt in such discourses for those excluded from infrastructures' benefits exemplifies this. Seldom is it as clearly expressed as in the KPMG (2016) report on 'Emerging Trends', likening terrorists to 'state-backed players bent on disrupting perceived enemies' and calling out 'never-do-wells and the disenfranchised seeking a new thrill or challenge'. Similarly, consultancies warn of infrastructure's vulnerability in the face of 'terrorism'.

> Terrorism is a very real threat to infrastructure (both physically and through cyber-attack), particularly in densely populated urban areas and during major events where any action can have devastating and far-reaching consequences. (KPMG, 2016, p. 9)

This discourse indicates how at least some investors perceive protest against infrastructures and demands for different ownership models, or more radical alternatives, as threats.

We conceptualize authoritarian practices in infrastructure expansion as going beyond mere limitations to participation. State authorities employ repressive practices in energy infrastructure construction against organized groups that contest them, and render the promise of connection illegitimate. While official imaginaries of transregional infrastructures are insensitive to the violence experienced by those contesting it, opposing movements employ a language embedded in larger narratives of colonial economy and war. They frame the new infrastructures as a threat to territory and livelihoods, rather than to private land (FMP, 2018). A critical analysis of infrastructures prefiguring politics, then, must document who exerts physical coercion in infrastructure expansion (Li, 2018). Both physical repression and indirect effects of energy infrastructure expansion can impede political mobilization, prefiguring politics. Frequently, intricate entanglements between private security and the military make it difficult to even know who is responsible for intimidation. For instance, paramilitary and criminal groups in Central America are well known as promoters and beneficiaries of infrastructure-led development.

Linkages between security and infrastructure are difficult to contest, as infrastructure vulnerability discourses have legitimized military presence. Through the 'war on drugs' and 'war on terror' tropes militaries assumed a transregional 'geoeconomic role' as path-breakers of capitalist infrastructural power (Khalili, 2018). Spaces of militarization and infrastructure increasingly merge. When interactions with states' coercive agencies define everyday experiences around infrastructures, contestation becomes almost impossible. Transregional electricity infrastructures have effectively fuelled coercive practices. Such practices target acts of 'disruptive democracy' that are conscious of 'the vulnerabilities of centralized energy systems' (occupations, blockages of plants, or disruption of cables) (Folkers, 2016). The greater vulnerability of transnationally interconnected systems – of disruptions at one point affecting energy flows at distant places – makes coercive practices even more likely.

The spatial differentiation fix

Contrasting state-centered politics, transnational electricity grids themselves become a field of struggle. We situate the politics of infrastructure expansion in a field of tension (see Mezzadra & Neilson, 2019, p. 236) that stretches beyond the state. Our analysis recognizes the specific tension arising through transregional electricity grids. These are part of a state-led spatial fix (Harvey, 2001) of global political economy, and constitute the material expression of efforts at linking metropolitan

nodes, capital, and technologies (i.e. different energy sources) in ways that ensure that they cease being bounded by national spaces (see Summers, 2016).

Transnational, and even transregional infrastructure projects produce newly assembled relational spaces of politics (Arboleda, 2020, p. 5; see Addie et al., 2020). Authoritarian practices are transregionally entangled, and geographical propinquity is not necessarily key for understanding them. Transnational electricity grids connecting far-distant places illustrate 'novel modalities of state power' which 'cannot be fully elucidated by … state-centric concepts of political economy … ' (Arboleda, 2020, p. 5). Recognizing the influence of local agents at specific sites *and* globally dispersed actors (Sovacool & Cooper, 2013, p. 6) concurs with the situatedness and scale of transregional infrastructure expansion. This is not a new proposition, but the material network of infrastructures underpinning global social relations of production and circulation has become ever more intricate (pipelines, cables, transmission lines, roads). The promise of seamless electricity flows suggests connective processes in itself, and that 'electricity systems are more stable the more meshed and interconnected they are' (Red Eléctrica de Espana, 2012, p. 5).

The grids have not made statecraft superfluous, but rather, global capital, materialized inter alia in these grids, has facilitated its coercive configurations (without the need for a transnational state) (Arboleda, 2020, p. 6). Transregional electricity grids are a fundamental illustration not of a transnational state (that would regulate infrastructure planning or investment practices at a global scale or provide organizational coherence), but of the tensions between states as an expression of social relations, and transnationally oriented accumulation, and between these states facilitating capital accumulation, and social struggles contesting the latter (Hesketh, 2018, p. 583). Dynamic transnational formations are 'mediated and restrained by competing social forces that remain organized through differentiated territorial jurisdictions' (Hesketh, 2018, p. 578). The aspired seamless interconnectivity is never completely reached, and in fact highly selective. Capital accumulation may face limits in one location, and build on prior investments in another. Units of production for the grids span different countries, but location remains key, as requirements for infrastructure design, measurements, environmental assessment regulations, demands for interconnection plans and feasibility studies, and the specific social forces involved, differ from one location to the next.

We understand the global not as an external relation of existing states, and states not as self-contained entities which could ever have contained social relations (Bieler & Morton, 2018). No easy top-down hierarchy of global or transnational capitalists imposes projects onto passive states. Instead, transregional energy infrastructures illustrate how capitalism is articulated through multi-scalar relations (Morton, 2013). (Global) capital is a social relation that requires the national as much as the global, both of which constitute one another.

In sum, while social struggles are frequently compartmentalized into different states, we cannot understand transregional energy infrastructures solely through the spatial fix of the national scale. Instead, we have to analyse the uneven and combined ways and extent through which the interests of transnational capital are realized, and simultaneously work through the contradictions of heterogeneous social constellations within state territoriality, and the increasingly similar conditions of production, investment networks, and imaginaries (Bieler & Morton, 2018). State agencies, through this spatial fix and grand regional connectivity imaginaries, facilitate capital accumulation for companies and to the detriment of the wider public, for instance by guaranteeing high prices, as occurred in Morocco between Saudi ACWA Power, the Moroccan state-owned electricity company Office Nationale de l'Électricité et de l'Eau (ONEE) and the publicly-owned Moroccan Agency for Sustainable Energy (MASEN). In some locations such as Guatemala or Honduras, corporations do

not even go through open tender processes for state contracts. Instead, companies frequently design projects, carry out the feasibility study (including authorization), and then sell them to larger companies developing them (Geocomunes, 2019, p. 19).

In transregional electricity grids, states share infrastructural power across relationally connected spaces, instead of exercising it directly. Infrastructural control lies with globally active corporations, consultancies, and development banks. The privatization of infrastructure investments and energy infrastructure networks is a key feature of large-scale contemporary infrastructural projects, with most being transnational public-private joint ventures. Public private partnerships in 2018 alone amounted to $90 billion of infrastructure investments across 335 projects (Di Liddo et al., 2019, p. 524). With the privatization of urban and energy infrastructures in the 1990s and 2000s, public infrastructure providers ceded sovereign rights over an element that governments particularly rely on in a globally competitive economy. Unsurprisingly, large-scale infrastructure players have a strong political standing and have been involved in authoritarian practices to guarantee investment returns (Pike et al., 2019).

The prefiguration of politics is not constrained to a national or subnational scale. Cross-border infrastructure politics differs from other kinds of transborder relations due to the fundamental role its materiality plays in shaping how societies can function. The lock-in of energy choices, capital, and above all state budgets and development bank loans bound up in large-scale projects over long periods of time, and dependencies fixed around the construction and operation of these infrastructures, deeply affect future politics.

This article cannot delve into the depths of debates on financialization and debt. However, the financing of large-scale infrastructures primarily by development banks and the path dependencies associated with the large investments by states themselves, affect future politics. Corporations, in turn, provide only a fraction of the investment for each project, but frequently boost profits by selling both electricity and carbon credit. Safety nets for investors, which protect profits from fluctuating demand, changing political contexts, climate regulation and currency risks, are only possible as risks are transferred to the state (Gabor, 2021). This contemporary set-up of infrastructure ownership, consumption, production, and flows through the grid is indicative of a highly exclusionary energy future.

An often-overlooked authoritarian element of electricity grids is the increasing intertwinement with migration containment infrastructures. The imaginary of global connectivity that undergirds projects such as SIEPAC or MedRing (re-)produces inequalities that let privileged individuals and goods move more freely than others. The connections produced are highly selective. Governments and corporations promote the regional flow of electricity and energy as necessary for future 'progress'. Yet the containment of people is just as integral to these infrastructure expansions. Tensions arise in transregional (energy) infrastructure between containment and (energy) flows, based on categories of race and class.

The differentiated transnational spatial fix prefigures politics via stabilizing specific labour relations across constituencies. Key providers of energy and its main consumers are often located at far distant ends of such electricity grids, replicating a North–South divide. This makes for highly unequal and quasi-colonial relations between different sites of the chain. Studies of transnational grids must recognize the – frequently invisible – grounding of infrastructure in racialized labour exploitation and occupation (Plonski, 2022). While interconnections such as SIEPAC and MedRing might reduce electricity costs, border policing facilitates low labour costs due to the steady supply of exploitable illegalized immigrant labour. In addition, hierarchized and racialized property regimes may facilitate land expropriation. Such infrastructural effects contribute to political settings which

deepen existing asymmetries between those who are heard and those who have little access to infrastructure planning.

We propose paying attention to technocratic, preemptive and coercive practices in infrastructure planning, and to the contemporary spatial fix beyond the state, in which infrastructures nonetheless themselves become part and parcel of containment practices and extended border infrastructures.

Two cases of transregional energy infrastructures

Below, we briefly introduce two transregional electricity projects in an effort to illustrate parts of our argument and conceptual approach.

MEDRING

For relations between the EU and the MENA in the field of electricity, the project for a Mediterranean electricity ring (MedRing) constitutes the key governing framework. Aiming at the reinforcement of existing and the establishment of new bidirectional electricity interconnections, it seeks to facilitate the expansion of renewables in the MENA and the transfer of electricity to Europe (for a discussion of the regional electricity grid in the Arabian Peninsula, see Günel, 2018). The only existing electric line crossing the Mediterranean connects Spain and Morocco and became operational in 1998. In 2003, the Spanish and Moroccan transmission system operators Red Electrica de Espana (REE), a partly-state owned public limited corporation with assets in Portugal, Peru and Bolivia, and ONEE, Morocco's state-owned electricity company, contracted a Norwegian-Italian consortium for a €115 million project to lay a second cable, doubling the previous capacity to a total of 1,400 MW. In 2006, the 31 km long cable was installed between Tarifa, Spain, and Fardioua, Morocco, at a maximum depth of 620 m. Plans are underway for laying a third interconnector by 2026.

In 2018, after years of Spanish net electricity exports, the Spain-Morocco interconnector, a subcomponent of the MedRing project, saw Moroccan electricity exports surmounting imports from Spain for the first time. Facilitating greater integration with the European electricity market, the Spain-Morocco interconnector needs to be analysed in conjunction with the Moroccan Solar Plan and its main constituent projects, such as the 500 MW Noor concentrated solar power (CSP) mega-plant near the city of Ouarzazate, which now connects with the European grid. Noor, the world's largest CSP plant, was developed by Saudi ACWA Power and a Spanish consortium around Acciona, which, until 2009, also held 25% of ENDESA, which is involved in our other case, SIEPAC. The state-owned Spanish holding company Sociedad Estatal de Participaciones Industriales (SEPI) not only holds 20% of the Spanish transmission systems operator REE, but also 2.9% of ENDESA. Contractual arrangements between MASEN, which is in charge of the Moroccan Solar Plan, ONEE and Saudi ACWA, which operates and maintains the plant with MASEN, have led to losses by publicly-owned MASEN that amounted to approximately € 75 million in 2020 alone (CESE, 2020, p. 32).

The interconnector is both a force of integration (of the Moroccan economy into European 'development') and exclusion. The European Commission (2004) considered its reinforcement a 'priority project' and drew up images of a 'common energy future' (MEDREG, 2021), claiming that infrastructure investments would bring prosperity to the entire region. As the project is rendered a seeming necessity, questions about the uneven distribution of economic benefits, and about the colonial strategies for territorial dispossession that enabled the acquisition of the land necessary

for solar energy development in for instance Ouarzazate (Rignall, 2016, p. 543) are largely ignored. The shareholders of the industrial initiative MedGrid (2010), which supports MedRing, openly aim at 'promoting the involvement of Europe and European solutions in matters of climate change'. Technocratic descriptions of transregional energy infrastructures as inevitable components of global attempts at energy transition only perpetuate these power imbalances and marginalize contestation.

The Mediterranean electricity ring and the integration of North Africa into a Eurocentric energy politics prioritizes notions of European energy security, and benefits transnational corporations and authoritarian elites. In Moroccan-occupied Western Sahara, power cuts, unequal energy distribution and discrimination along ethnic lines are used as a form of punishment, and contrast with the Moroccan regime's, the EU's, and private energy developers' discourses of clean energy and global connectivity. Western Sahara Resource Watch (WSRW, 2014) has documented cases of forced eviction to make place for electricity lines. Protests against (renewable) energy infrastructures directly link these to colonialism and occupation, and are met with brutal violence by Moroccan security authorities. Importantly, many Sahrawis see little distinction between involved foreign energy companies and the Moroccan regime, and talk of one 'energopolitical regime' (Allan et al., 2021, pp. 9–10).

It is of crucial importance to realize the selective nature of the offered interconnectivity and its constitutive role for forms of exclusion and repression, including racialized labour exploitation, the fight against migration and the Moroccan occupation of Western Sahara. The integration of the Spanish and Moroccan grids then appears much less as an indicator for the surmounting of established boundaries, than as a project that deepens existing asymmetries. The Spain-Morocco interconnector must not only be understood in connection with Spanish-Moroccan cooperation in the fight against migration, but as co-constituting the latter. It facilitates European consumption of RE generated in North Africa and directly upholds the economic profitability of the Spanish agricultural sector and racialized labour exploitation characteristic of the latter (Hoggart & Mendoza, 2000). Finally, the Spain-Morocco interconnector is an excellent demonstration of the selective nature of the connectivity produced and enabled by transregional energy infrastructures.

SIEPAC

In 2008, the governments of Central American states and Mexico agreed to construct SIEPAC, a transnational electricity transmission line of 1.800 km with a capacity of 300 MW. It operates commercially since 2014, and cost 505 million US$. SIEPAC is the energy component of the Mesoamerican Project, a giant infrastructure plan between Mexico, Central America and Colombia, promising unhindered future energy flows across the hemisphere.

The precondition for SIEPAC was a contingent process of privatization of practically all Central American electricity networks in the 1990s, to facilitate the emerging Regional Electricity Market. Both the formerly public Spanish electricity provider Empresa Nacional de Electricidad (ENDESA) – its majority shareholder now being Italian energy giant ENEL – and the Interamerican Development Bank, SIEPAC's main investor, had pushed for integrated electricity infrastructures (Geocomunes, 2019, pp. 9–10). EPR, a corporation based in San José, Costa Rica, built and operates SIEPAC. EPR's shareholders are the national electricity providers of Central American countries, private corporations in their majority, and ENEL Américas, which also generates energy via 18 hydroelectric plants in Guatemala, Costa Rica, and Panama (Geocomunes, 2019). The Colombia-based transnational electricity corporation ISA and Mexican Energy Commission CFE joined

as extra-regional shareholders in 2005 and 2008 respectively. At the start of operations, every shareholder held shares certificates of 6.5 million US$ (OECD, 2017).

SIEPAC was part of the Mesoamerican project since 2001 under the Tuxtla Dialogue Mechanism, which united the Governments of Mexico, Belize and Central America, but its planning process was not particpatory. Shareholder meetings are, unsurprisingly, not accessible to the public, yet take far-reaching decisions affecting large populations across the isthmus. A leading Costa Rican environmentalist said 'the decision-making process over SIEPAC was absolutely authoritarian' (Interview 11 May, 2022). Already in 2006, Subcomandante Marcos (2006), then spokesperson for the Zapatistas movement, warned ENDESA's involvement in SIEPAC would mirror ENDESA's repression against Chilean indigenous communities that had protested the company's hydropower investments.

SIEPAC illustrates the integration of electricity infrastructures into transregional containment efforts between North and Central America. The city of Tapachula at the Mexican-Guatemalan border, the site of the actual interconnection between the Mexican grid and SIEPAC at the Guatemalan town of Los Brillantes and a major migration hub, exemplifies the juxtaposition of energy flows and the containment of people. The Development Plan for Central America, devised by the UN Economic Commission's Mexico office (CEPAL, 2019), promises to reduce migratory flows by pushing for infrastructure-led development and growth, explicitly naming SIEPAC as one means to achieve this. It plans to improve the Mexico-SIEPAC interconnection running through Tapachula, a megaproject worth 300 Mio. US$. Recent accounts of Tapachula invariably describe 'large numbers' of migrants stranded there; increased border policing forces migrants into more dangerous routes. Invoking the technopolitical promises of the Mesoamerican Project, the plan stresses the 'enormous potential' of 'coordinated logistics and mobility' politics for the region (CEPAL, 2019), i.e. transnational electricity transmission lines and gas pipelines.

Curbing movement of Central America's racialized populations became explanatory and a motive for electricity connectivity. Additionally, the Mexican government declared a 'containment zone' across the entire Isthmus of Tehuantepec, the Mesoamerican Project's Mexican area, which the connector links with SIEPAC. The government framed infrastructure plans for the Mexican Isthmus between the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans as 'borders' – hoping 'that regional development projects act as 'curtains' to capture migratory flows in their transit to the north' (Presidencia de la República, 2019, p. 31) –, despite simultaneously recognizing the socio-economic reasons for out-migration towards the US. State officials and trade sector representatives mobilized surveillance infrastructure improve transnational trade. For instance, the Project for Technological Integration of Customs (PITA) in turn, aimed to top up surveillance mechanisms, passenger controls, and goods revisions both at borders and within the country. This added electricity demand for border infrastructures to the mix.

Conclusion

Transregional electricity grids allow us to see the specific tensions that arise from states facilitating capital accumulation between related sites with different social struggles. Globalized infrastructure spaces are materializations of the principle that authoritarian practices do not stop at state borders, and their contestation likewise requires transregional efforts. The Central American transmission grid reconfigured the region by design, extending more clearly than ever energy flows from a site of resource to industrial and export hubs, yet bypassing – and generating blind spots around – the communities affected by newly built power plants and connections. The Spain-Morocco

interconnector, while facilitating the borderless flow of energy between two continents, builds on and reinforces different types of authoritarian practices. These include colonial strategies of dispossession, the Moroccan occupation of Western Sahara, the prevention of alternative visions of 'energy democracy', and racialized labour exploitation and the fight against migration.

This article develops a framework for analysing authoritarian practices that state and non-state actors may employ in the expansion of transregional (energy) infrastructures. Increased electricity interconnections prefigure politics in ways that may inhibit participatory and inclusive energy futures. Large-scale infrastructures can radically alter a terrain, and restructure a region in the service of larger flows (of goods and privileged people). Building on a political economy reading, it becomes clear that – in transregional energy infrastructure projects – state power indeed 'disavows itself', despite infrastructure's immediacy and intimacy (see Anand et al., 2018, p. 21). The monopolization of livelihoods under a specific production system and the subordination of law are enabled by forms of infrastructural violence. In our cases, electricity grids do not directly work to subordinate people, but the energy production platforms the grids connect with (wind, coal, solar), do. The integration into transnational interconnections set specific political and economic dynamics in motion that facilitate this subordination. While global infrastructure corporations are entangled with local political relations, they distance themselves from potentially critical 'locals' via practices of technocratisation and repression. This limits avenues for future contestation and prevents alternative energy politics.

Transregional electricity grids illustrate how transnational infrastructures change politics and prefigure the politically possible. States share infrastructural power across relationally connected spaces with other states, and with energy provision and infrastructure corporations. In consequence, social struggles may still be compartmentalized into different states, but to understand the politics of transregional energy infrastructures we have to look beyond the spatial fix of the national scale. Building on existing scholarship on the tensions between statecraft and global capital accumulation, we suggest that analyses of transregional electricity grids need to recognize the uneven and combined ways and extent through which the interests of transnational capital are realized.

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